



A PUBLIC bathroom that once stood on the Santa Cruz pier bobs in the ocean after the outermost portion of the structure washed away.

Huge waves pummel Santa Cruz: ‘It looks like a bomb went off’

Section of city’s wharf collapses, and a man dies after being pinned under debris

BY NATHAN SOLIS,
CLARA HARTER AND
SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

The city of Santa Cruz is reeling after a powerful storm sent waves crashing into Monterey Bay, damaging a pier and killing a person farther south who became pinned under debris.

By Tuesday morning, a public bathroom that once stood on the wharf bobbed along the coast. Local

beaches remained closed because of the risk of hazardous debris washing ashore, and city officials are still assessing the extent of the damage.

“It’s total chaos,” Surf School Santa Cruz owner Bud Freitas told The Times. “I just did a drive through the south side of town, and the beaches are all tore up. It looks like a bomb went off.”

The previous day, monstrous waves slammed into Monterey Bay, driven by

hurricane-force winds hundreds of miles away. It’s a regular occurrence along the Central Coast this time of year, said National Weather Service meteorologist Roger Gass.

In December 2023, a storm surge damaged the wharf and forced the city to close the structure to the public. The city demolished a restaurant at the end of the wharf, and officials planned to complete repairs to the wharf by March 2025.

But then came a high surf warning Sunday, with the weather service reporting waves peaking at over 40 feet.

Freitas, who grew up surfing in Santa Cruz, said Monday’s swells were some of the biggest he’s seen in his life. Locals were aware of the conditions on the wharf, but he was in shock when he started to see videos of it washing away.

“I never thought it would have happened, but you

know the ocean wins again,” he said.

The high surf warning was in effect until 6 p.m. Tuesday, when the waves were expected to subside.

In the meantime, officials are urging people across the region to stay out of the water and avoid piers, marinas and the beach. High surf was also expected along some Southern California beaches, approaching 18 feet in Ventura County and 12 [See **Waves**, A7]

ANALYSIS

Trump starts to walk back promises

After casting himself as a problem solver, the president-elect is throwing in caveats.

BY KEVIN RECTOR

Throughout his campaign, President-elect Donald Trump promised national prosperity and global peace, saying he would quickly drive down the cost of groceries in local supermarkets and bring deadly overseas wars to an abrupt end.

He echoed that rosy message during a wide-ranging news conference last week, saying his second term “will be the most exciting and successful period of reform and renewal in all of American history, maybe of global history.”

“The Golden Age of America, I call it,” he said. “It’s begun.”

Then again, maybe not. Trump also offered a caveat — a warning that things could go badly wrong, such as when the COVID-19 pandemic erupted “out of nowhere” during his first term [See **Analysis**, A5]

COLUMN ONE

He made the NBA, but as an exec

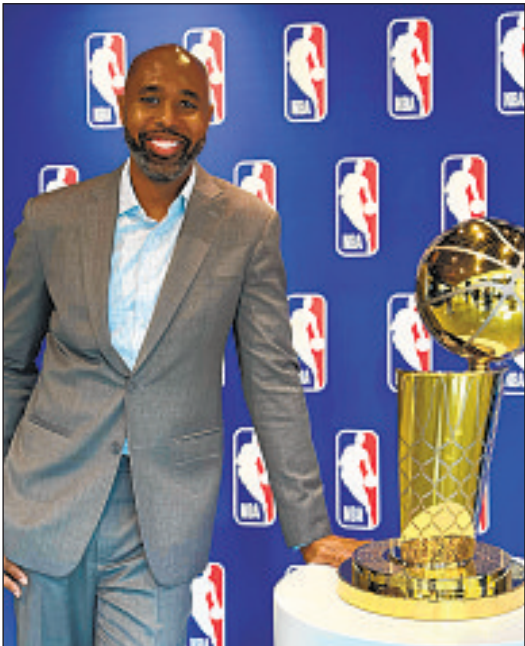
A Los Angeles native who worked at Google and the White House brings tech and legal skills to the league’s oft-questioned officiating

BY DAN WOIKE

Albert Sanders Jr., the boy with the big dreams and the bigger drive, was scared. He was angry. Worried.

He wanted to become a lawyer, to wow courtrooms just like Ben Matlock and Perry Mason did on his family’s clunky console TV. But in 1994, when he was 14, that dream suddenly seemed beyond reach, hence the anger and worry. He had excelled at a private school, but circumstances had brought him to Jefferson High School, one of the worst in Los Angeles.

Before his first day as a freshman, he and his mother, Paula Sanders, sat in front of the campus in her 11-year-old Volvo as she fought to hide tears.



ALBERT Sanders Jr., who grew up as a fan of NBA and court dramas, says his basketball coach rightly steered him toward law school.

“How am I going to realize this dream of being a lawyer and maybe working in politics one day when I’m at a school where half the kids don’t graduate?” Albert wondered.

But that was on the inside.

“He said, ‘Mom, I know what to do,’” Paula Sanders remembered. “And I believed him.”

It was trust well placed. Sanders would grow up to work on Capitol Hill, at the White House and at Google. These days he is head of referee operations in the NBA and one of the most important people in professional basketball.

The role may seem improbable. He’s never blown a whistle, never called a foul. But to those who know him and recall the boy who grew up in South L.A., his journey is not so surprising. [See **Sanders**, A10]

Shooting down recent hysteria

There’s no need to panic about black plastic and drones, Michael Hiltzik says. **PERSPECTIVES**, A2

A bomb threat’s unlikely suspect

LAPD has to take such calls seriously, but City Hall hoax has many in disbelief. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

U.S. sues banks over Zelle fraud

Financial giants left victims “to fend for themselves,” agency chief says. **BUSINESS**, A6

Weather

Morning fog, then sun. L.A. Basin: 65/49. **B6**

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Is Wells Fargo’s move a bad sign for state?

San Francisco bank’s shift to leased offices may be the latest evidence of sector’s drift from California.

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO

When news broke last week that Wells Fargo would be selling its longtime San Francisco headquarters and relocating to leased digs down the street, some viewed it as a gentle breakup — letting someone down easy only to eventually hit them with the hard truth.

California’s most prominent financial institution has been intimately tied to the city since its Gold Rush-era founding in 1852. But over the last several decades Wells Fargo has gobbled up rivals, making it the nation’s fourth-largest bank and leaving it with operations across the country — and an executive team nearly 3,000 miles away.

Chief Executive Charles Scharf, tapped to turn Wells Fargo around after the bank’s accounts scandals of the last decade, has been steering the company from New York City — nowhere near the 12-story tower at 420 Montgomery St. in San Francisco’s Financial District, its headquarters since 1960, where a fabled stagecoach that recalls its historic logo is on display.

The announcement has prompted speculation that the company’s downsizing in the Bay Area is only a prelude to an eventual move of its official corporate headquarters to a lower-cost location such as Dallas or Charlotte, N.C., while its executive team stays on Wall Street — though Wells Fargo denies that.

“It’s a sign to folks that it’s just not a California-headquartered bank anymore,” said Gerard Cassidy, a banking analyst with RBC Capital Markets. “They are building a universal bank under the Wells Fargo name.”

Whatever the eventuality, Wells Fargo’s departure from its longtime headquarters underscores the diminished role the state and city play as financial centers even as the San Francisco Bay Area has transformed itself over the last half a century into the world’s leading tech center, replete with scores of venture capital firms.

In 1998, San Francisco was stunned when Bank of America, whose origins date to the early 1900s, announced it was merging with NationsBank and moving its corporate headquarters to Charlotte amid the same wave of industry consolidation that transformed its crosstown rival.

Wells Fargo downplayed its move, issuing a statement last week that it planned to remain in the city and the decision was part of a “multiyear effort to build a stronger, more efficient Wells Fargo” and to move to a “more modern building that can deliver a better experience.” [See **Wells**, A7]



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